

IN CONTEXT

Russia's first professional composer

Tchaikovsky was the first Russian composer to be fully “professional.” His five leading contemporaries, known as the Mighty Handful or The Five (see Modest Mussorgsky), were mainly self-taught and, at best, part-timers, at worst, excellent amateurs when it came to writing music (for example, Borodin was a chemist and Rimsky-Korsakov a naval officer). Tchaikovsky was freer than them—thanks largely to the 14 years of financial support he enjoyed from Nadezhda von Meck.

Born in Votkinsk in 1840, Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky was the son of a mining engineer. A sensitive, impressionable child, when sent away to school he threw himself out of the carriage to try to run home to his mother. Her death from cholera in 1854 devastated him.

At the School of Jurisprudence in St. Petersburg, the young Pyotr sang in the choir (“My voice was a splendid soprano,” he recalled), played the piano, and began to try composing. He also developed close friendships. Both he and his younger brother, Modest, were homosexual.

“ **Inspiration** is a **guest** that does not willingly **visit** the **lazy**. ”

PYOTR ILYICH TCHAIKOVSKY